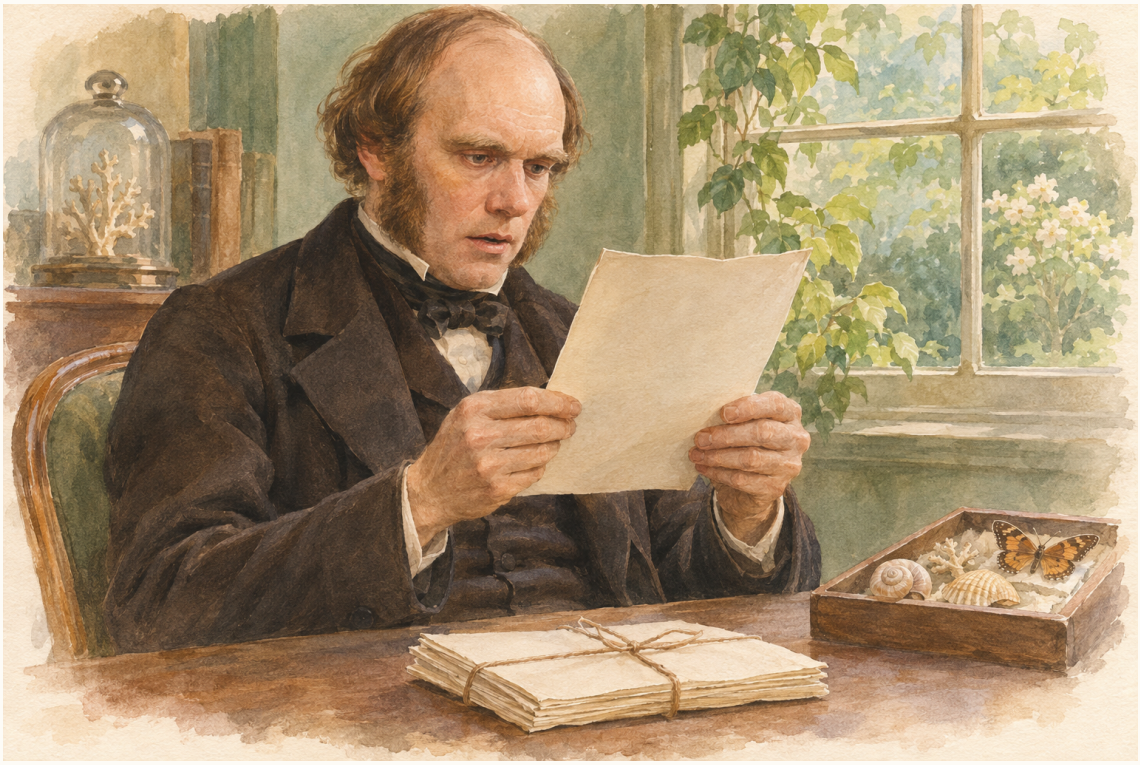
一封信惊醒了达尔文

The Letter That Startled Darwin



华莱士的来信为何让达尔文不安?

READ 纯净阅读

CHECK 中文核对

LEARN 词汇记忆

RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

Charles Darwin disembarked from HMS Beagle in October 1836. In September 1838 he began formulating the principle of natural selection: individuals better adapted to their surroundings survive and pass on their hereditary traits. By 1844 he had composed a 230-page manuscript, yet kept it unpublished, cautiously amassing evidence.

In February 1858, two decades after Darwin's first insight, Alfred Russel Wallace, a naturalist afflicted by fever in the Malay Archipelago, independently conceived the same idea. His concise essay reached Darwin on 18 June 1858. Its argument paralleled Darwin's own almost precisely; he told Charles Lyell he had never seen a more remarkable coincidence. His claim to priority seemed threatened.

Lyell and the botanist Joseph Hooker arranged for both papers to be read simultaneously at the Linnean Society, a scientific institution in London, on 1 July 1858. Neither author attended the proceedings. Wallace was abroad, and Darwin was grieving: scarlet fever had killed his infant son on 28 June. The compromise, struck without Wallace, may have kept rivalry over precedence at bay.

The papers' publication on 20 August 1858 met a muted reception. In May 1859 the Society's president remarked in his yearly address that the year had been barren of revolutionary discoveries. The sensation came on 24 November 1859 with Darwin's treatise, On the Origin of Species: booksellers had subscribed for every copy of its first impression, 1,250 in all.

Wallace had readily signified his acceptance in October 1858, assuring Hooker in a cordial letter of his satisfaction with the arrangement. In 1889 he published a lengthy exposition of the idea and entitled it Darwinism. Wallace never named the theory after himself.

中文译文

1836年10月，查尔斯·达尔文从小猎犬号下船。1838年9月，他开始形成自然选择原理：更能适应环境的个体存活下来，把遗传性状传给后代。到1844年，他已写出230页手稿，却没有发表，仍谨慎地积累证据。

1858年2月，也就是达尔文最初产生这个想法约二十年后，博物学家阿尔弗雷德·拉塞尔·华莱士在马来群岛身患热病时，独立想到了同一原理。他的简短论文于1858年6月18日送达达尔文手中，论证与达尔文自己的几乎完全一致。达尔文告诉查尔斯·莱尔，他从未见过如此惊人的巧合。他对首创地位的主张，似乎受到了威胁。

莱尔和植物学家约瑟夫·胡克安排两人的论文于1858年7月1日在伦敦的科学机构林奈学会上同场宣读。两位作者都没有到场：华莱士身在海外，达尔文则正沉浸在悲痛中——6月28日，猩红热夺走了他幼子的生命。这个在华莱士未参与商定的情况下达成的折中办法，或许避免了一场首创权之争。

论文于1858年8月20日发表，反响平淡。1859年5月，学会会长甚至在年度致辞中说，这一年没有革命性的发现。真正的轰动直到1859年11月24日达尔文的专著《物种起源》出版时才到来：书商已把首印的1250册全部订走。

华莱士已于1858年10月欣然表示接受这一安排，并在写给胡克的亲切信件中说明自己对此感到满意。1889年，他又出版了一部详细阐述这一思想的著作，题名《达尔文主义》。他从未用自己的名字为这套理论命名。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

formulate v.
形成并表述
he began formulating the principle of

principle n.
原理；原则
he began formulating the principle of

adapted to adj.phr.
适应……的
individuals better adapted to their

hereditary adj.
遗传的
and pass on their hereditary traits.

trait n.
性状；特征
and pass on their hereditary traits.

manuscript n.
手稿
he had composed a 230-page manuscript,

amass v.
积累；大量收集
it unpublished, cautiously amassing

afflicted by adj.phr.
遭受……折磨的
a naturalist afflicted by fever in the

independently adv.
独立地
independently conceived the same idea.

conceive v.
构想出
independently conceived the same idea.

concise adj.
简明的
His concise essay reached Darwin on 18

coincidence n.
巧合
seen a more remarkable coincidence.

priority n.
首创地位；优先权
claim to priority seemed threatened.

simultaneously adv.
同时地
to be read simultaneously at the

compromise n.
折中方案
compromise, struck without Wallace,

rivalry n.
竞争
may have kept rivalry over precedence

precedence n.
领先地位；先后次序
may have kept rivalry over precedence

muted adj.
平淡的；不热烈的
20 August 1858 met a muted reception.

reception n.
反响；接受情况
20 August 1858 met a muted reception.

cordial adj.
亲切友好的
a cordial letter of his satisfaction

exposition n.
详细阐述
a lengthy exposition of the idea and

entitle v.
为……题名
exposition of the idea and entitled it

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共38项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

disembark v.
下船；登岸

selection n.
选择；筛选

surroundings n.
周围环境

pass on phr.v.
传递；传给后代

compose v.
撰写

unpublished adj.
未发表的

cautiously adv.
谨慎地

naturalist n.
博物学家

parallel v.
与……十分相似

precisely adv.
精确地；完全地

remarkable adj.
非同寻常的

threaten v.
威胁

botanist n.
植物学家

arrange for phr.v.
安排……发生

institution n.
机构

proceedings n.
会议；会议活动

grieve v.
悲痛；哀悼

scarlet adj.
猩红色的；构成猩红热一词

infant adj.
婴幼儿的

文中词汇与搭配 续

补充词汇共38项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

publication n.
发表；出版

remark v.
评论；说

yearly adj.
年度的

barren of adj.phr.
缺乏；毫无

revolutionary adj.
革命性的

sensation n.
轰动

treatise n.
专著

On the Origin of Species proper n.
《物种起源》

subscribe for phr.v.
预订；订购

impression n.
印次；一次印刷

readily adv.
欣然地；毫不迟疑地

signify v.
表示；表明

acceptance n.
接受

assure v.
向……保证

satisfaction n.
满意

arrangement n.
安排

lengthy adj.
篇幅很长的

name after phr.v.
与after连用：以……命名

after prep.
标示命名所依据的人

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 cautiously _____ evidence.

02 His claim to _____ seemed threatened.

03 met a _____ reception.

04 assuring Hooker in a _____ letter

文章主线

- 酝酿 达尔文1838年构想自然选择：更适应环境者存活并传下遗传性状；1844年已写成230页手稿，仍搜证未发表。
- 来信 华莱士独立构想同一原理，1858年来稿几乎与达尔文一致，令达尔文担心自己的首创地位。
- 折中 莱尔、胡克安排两人成果于1858年7月同场宣读；两位作者都未出席，华莱士也未参与商定办法。
- 反响 论文发表初期反响冷淡；1859年《物种起源》引起轰动，首印1250册已被书商全部订购。
- 认可 华莱士1858年10月事后致信认可安排；1889年又以《达尔文主义》阐述自然选择，未用自己名字命名理论。

参考答案　1 amassing 2 priority 3 muted 4 cordial